

Have you ever thought about why we follow rules? Why we break them? Or why we sacrifice what we value for the people we love? Composers undeniably shape our understanding of others, using human experiences to reveal the complex internal conflicts that influence how individuals act and respond to their world. Stephen Daldry's bildungsroman musical film 'Billy Elliot' and O. Henry's romantic literary fiction 'The Gift of the Magi' are perfect testaments to the power of storytelling to portray the human behaviours of self-sacrifice, how our identities are formed under social and economic restraints, and the way these experiences reveal profound truths about individuals and relationships. **And honestly, once you start unpacking these texts, you realise they aren't just stories but reflections of ourselves.** Both Stephen Daldry and O. Henry demonstrate how human behaviours are shaped by love, pressure, and personal values, **and they do it in powerful ways that genuinely make us reconsider how we see others and the world.**

There come moments in our lives where we need to stop and consider whether someone else's happiness is more important than our own. In 'Billy Elliot', Daldry skilfully uses close-ups, low key lighting, and diegetic sound to reveal Jackie's turmoil when he secretly watches Billy dance. The close-up exposes his emotional fracture, the moment his belief that boys should be tough and masculine clashes with the realisation of Billy's talent. The low lighting reflects the vulnerability of his struggle, while diegetic sound from Billy's soft movements draws Jackie into recognising his son's passion. **Suddenly, it's like we're standing beside Jackie, as we learn love knows no bounds. It's unstoppable. He is torn between** enforcing traditional gender expectations and following his parental instinct to support Billy, offering us deeper insight into how love can challenge systemic beliefs and transform human behaviour. **It's the kind of moment that sticks with you because it's so emotionally raw and real.**

Later, Daldry omits sound and meticulously uses low-angle shots and close-ups when Jackie decides to return to the mines to fund Billy's audition. The silence is loud, emphasising the emotional weight of his choice, while the low-angle shot presents a close up of his conflicted expression, conveying the pressure and danger he faces. Jackie sacrifices **not only** his safety but also his pride and long-held beliefs. **You can almost feel your stomach drop when you realise his altruistic decision, which conflicts with earlier beliefs.** This moment reveals how humans

confront fear, responsibility, and loyalty, conveying how love can drive people to reconsider their values and change their behaviour to challenge social or personal limitations.

Moving onto 'The Gift of the Magi', O. Henry uses metaphor and emotive language through Della's hair, described as a "stream of brown water", to convey how much it means to her. But similar to Jackie, she goes against what she values and makes the ultimate sacrifice for love. When she cuts and sells it, her hesitation highlights the emotional cost of the choice. Her inconsistent behaviour shows how individuals will give up something deeply personal for someone they love. It's a simple moment, but it reminds us how identity can shift when devotion becomes more important than personal comfort as her sacrifice helps us understand how love can reshape identity and influence the choices people make.

O. Henry uses situational irony and symbolism when Jim admits, "I sold the watch to get the money to buy your combs." The irony hits because both gifts are now useless, yet the moment still feels incredibly tender. Jim's watch and Della's hair symbolise their identities, his connection to family history and her personal pride. It's almost funny and heartbreaking at the same time, because by sacrificing these symbols, they show how love makes us act out our emotions, pushing people to give up the things that define them. The irony helps us realise that the real value isn't the objects at all, but the emotional honesty behind their choices. O. Henry uses this to show audiences how genuine love reveals the truth of human behaviour far more clearly than material objects ever could.

The formation of identity is undoubtedly shaped by social and economic pressures when individuals are influenced by expectations that limit their choices and opportunities. In Billy Elliot, Daldry uses the sharp contrast between the cold, harsh lighting of the boxing hall and the

warm, soft glow of the ballet studio to capture **Billy caught between who he's expected to be and who he actually is**. Along with the tight framing of Billy in the boxing ring, these techniques reveal how “boxed in” he feels by social expectations, get it? “BOXED IN”. This contrast helps us understand our “Performative behaviours” that meet what society wants, while quietly protecting our real identity. It makes us pause and think about how often we do this in real life, deepening our understanding of how social pressure shapes behaviour.

Daldry also uses montage, diegetic sound, and wide shots of Billy practising in abandoned spaces to highlight his fight for self-expression. The echo of his footsteps and the emptiness around him show just how isolated he is, yet he remains resilient. It reinforces the idea that individuals carve out emotional and physical spaces to nurture identity, even when society attempts to restrict them.

Similarly, in ‘The Gift of the Magi’, O. Henry uses symbolism and contrast to illustrate how economic restraints shape identity. The sensory imagery of a cramped apartment with “a letter-box too small to hold a letter” and “an electric bell, but it could not make a sound” symbolises the financial limitations Della and Jim confront. This influences decisions and behaviour prioritising their relationship and emotions over practical ones. Through this, O. Henry offers fresh insight into how external limitations transform individual behaviours, valuing love over materialism

O. Henry also uses characterisation and the motif of money to reveal how poverty influences behaviour and identity. Della’s careful counting in “one cent and then another” reflects how financial pressure seeps into her thinking and shapes her sense of self. Money becomes a constant influence guiding her decisions, yet love motivates her final choice. This mirrors Jackie's sacrificial decision to sell his late wife’s watch, a nostalgic possession, to give Billy the life he desires. Through Della and Jim’s emotional generosity, O. Henry gives insight into human

behaviour, emphasising how people rebuild identity around connection and care even when economic restraints tighten around their lives.

Ultimately, it's undeniable that representations of human experiences offer meaningful insights into human behaviour when composers reveal emotional, social, and interpersonal struggles. Through exploring self-sacrifice and identity, 'Billy Elliot' and 'The Gift of the Magi' demonstrate how individuals respond to love, pressure, and hardship in ways that illuminate universal aspects of human behaviour. Thus, these texts highlight the complexity within the human experience; they make us realise how little we know about what motivates individuals' behaviour. Sometimes we just need that little reminder to transform the way we see the world, don't you think?